

home-hazard-hunt

The 20-Minute Home Hazard Hunt™

Find Every Tip-Over, Fall, and Leak Risk in Your Home — In One Pass

Why this worksheet exists: The single biggest myth about earthquakes is that the building is the danger. In the vast majority of quake injuries, the actual cause is a falling bookshelf, a toppled water heater, shattered glass, or an unsecured TV — not structural collapse. You cannot fix what you haven't found. This audit finds every hazard in your home in a single 20-minute room-by-room walk.

How to run it: Print this sheet (or open it on your phone). Walk each room in order below and check off every item you find. Don't fix anything during the hunt — just find and mark. Then execute the anchoring/fixes this week, prioritizing the items marked "HIGH."

The master rule: If it is tall, heavy, glass, or connected to gas/water and it is NOT secured, it is a hazard. Full stop.

Zone 1 — Kitchen (4 minutes)

Checklist — mark everything you find, note priority: - ☐ [HIGH]

Refrigerator not strapped/anchored (can tip forward in strong shaking) - ☐ [HIGH] Overhead cabinets without child-safety or seismic latches (contents fly out) - ☐ Heavy items stored on top shelves (move to lower shelves — gravity is the enemy) - ☐ Glassware/dishes in cabinets without latches (add rubber bumpers or latches) - ☐ Knife block or knives on open counters near edges - ☐ Hanging pot racks not secured to a joist - ☐ Gas stove/range not secured with a flexible gas line and anti-tip bracket - ☐ Heavy small appliances (stand mixer, toaster oven) near counter edges - ☐ Wine/liquor bottles on open shelving

Zone 1 tally: _____ hazards found

Zone 2 — Living Room & Family Room (4 minutes)

Checklist: - ☐ [HIGH] TV not secured with an anti-tip strap or wall mount - ☐ [HIGH] Bookshelves/tall furniture not anchored to wall studs - ☐ [HIGH] Glass-front cabinets or china cabinets not secured/latched - ☐ Mirrors and heavy art not on closed hooks (use closed hooks, not open ones) - ☐ Freestanding lamps in walkways (can fall and block exits) - ☐ Fireplace items (poker sets, glass doors)

not secured - ☐ Heavy decor on high shelves (move down or secure) - ☐
☐ Electronics/media units not anchored if tall/top-heavy - ☐ Ceiling fans / light fixtures with visible loose mounting

Zone 2 tally: _____ hazards found

Zone 3 — Bedrooms (4 minutes, repeat per bedroom)

Checklist: - ☐ [HIGH] Tall dressers/wardrobes not anchored (documented cause of child injuries — dressers tip onto beds) - ☐
[HIGH] Bed not positioned away from windows and tall furniture that could fall on it - ☐ Bookshelves not anchored - ☐ Mirrors on closets/walls not on closed hooks - ☐ Items on nightstands that could fall (lamps, glass items) - ☐ Closet shelving overloaded with items that could fall when door opens - ☐ Shoes/flashlight NOT kept by the bed (glass on the floor is a common post-quake injury — keep sturdy shoes and a flashlight within arm's reach of every bed)

Zone 3 tally: _____ hazards found (multiply by number of bedrooms audited)

Zone 4 — Bathroom & Utility Areas (4 minutes)

Checklist: - ☐ [HIGH] Water heater not strapped to wall studs (a top cause of house fires and floods after quakes — an unsecured tank can tip, rupture the gas line, and leak) - ☐ [HIGH] Gas shutoff valve location UNKNOWN or wrench not stored nearby (locate it now — see Tool #6 for the exact shutoff procedure) - ☐ Medicine cabinet items not secured (glass bottles, razors on open shelves) - ☐ Heavy mirror not on closed hooks - ☐ Washer/dryer not secured if stacked (stacking kits should be bolted) - ☐ Furnace/HVAC unit not secured or has flexible gas connector - ☐ Electrical panel access blocked by stored items (keep clear for emergency access) - ☐ Chemicals/cleaners stored on high, unsecured shelves (can spill/break, creating a hazardous mix)

Zone 4 tally: _____ hazards found

Zone 5 — Garage, Storage & Exterior (4 minutes)

Checklist: - ☐ [HIGH] Garage storage shelving not anchored (heavy tools/paint cans fall) - ☐ Chimney with visible cracks or loose masonry (have inspected — falling chimney material is a documented exterior hazard) - ☐ Exterior gas meter area clear and accessible (no storage blocking it) - ☐ Overhead garage storage racks overloaded or not rated for the load - ☐ Tall freestanding shelving in garage not anchored - ☐ Propane tanks / flammables not secured or stored per safety guidance - ☐ Exterior walkway/path clear of items that could block egress after a quake - ☐ Address numbers visible from the street (helps first responders find you fast)

The Verdict Sheet

- **Total hazards found:** _____
- **HIGH priority items (fix first):** _____
- **Gas shutoff location known?** Y / N — if N, fix this before anything else
- **Water heater strapped?** Y / N
- **A sturdy shoes + flashlight at every bed?** Y / N

Scorecard: - 0-5 hazards, all HIGH items secure: You're in excellent shape. - 6-15 hazards: Typical home. One focused weekend fixes most of it. - 16-25 hazards: Meaningful exposure. Prioritize the HIGH list this week — water heater strap and gas shutoff knowledge come first, always. - 25+ hazards: Don't panic — this is common in homes that have never been audited. Fix HIGH items this week, everything else over the next month.

Pro Tips From the Field

1. **Anchor kits are cheap and fast.** L-brackets, museum putty, furniture straps, and flexible gas line kits cost under \$50 total for a typical home and take a weekend to install. This is the highest-ROI prep action in the entire system.
 2. **Photograph the "before."** Photos of unsecured items become your fix-it list and your proof of progress in two weeks.
 3. **Do the bedrooms first if you have kids.** Tipped dressers onto beds are one of the most preventable and most common quake injuries to children.
 4. **Re-hunt after any renovation or new furniture.** New bookshelf, new TV, new baby's room — re-run the relevant zone.
 5. **Ask your landlord if you rent.** Water heater strapping and structural anchors may need landlord approval or a handyman — ask this week, not after the next quake.
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Your Next Step

You have the map. Now execute: fix every HIGH item this week, starting with the gas shutoff knowledge and the water heater strap. Then move to the **72-Hour Go-Bag Checklist (Tool #3)** to build your supply kit. The hunt finds it. The fixes end it.

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work or structural concerns.*